Decode Your Trauma Seminar – Day 1 Recording Notes

📝 Decode Your Trauma: Day One Notes
🕒 Started at 9:47AM on 29 Apr 2026, lasted 30m

Meeting Title: Decode Your Trauma – Day One

🗓️ 29 Apr, 2026
👥 Dr. Alex Howard

Outline

Program Overview and Format

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- Decode Your Trauma is a five-day guided series led by Dr. Alex Howard, aimed at helping participants make sense of past experiences and how they manifest in the mind, body, and heart.
- Running across eight time zones, the sessions are delivered via live stream rather than repeated live teachings, allowing participants to engage with each other through a chat function.
- A Q&A feature is available below the video on desktop or via the "More" menu on mobile and tablet devices, where qualified therapeutic coaches and Dr. Howard respond to participant questions.
- Qualified therapeutic coaches monitor the Q&A throughout each session, with the option to escalate unanswered questions directly to Dr. Howard.
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Decode Your Trauma Assessment Tool

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- A personalised assessment tool accompanies the five-day series, consisting of approximately 40 to 50 questions covering personal history and current life experiences.
- Completion of the tool generates a personalised report that categorises how trauma uniquely manifests for each participant, using defined clusters and elements.
- Designed to complement each daily session, the tool brings the framework to life through the participant's own lived experience, though the series remains fully standalone without it.
- Being in its beta phase, participant feedback on the tool's accuracy and resonance is actively encouraged to support its ongoing development.
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Series Objectives

- Demystifying trauma is identified as a central goal, alongside helping participants understand how trauma shows up in their present lives.
- Building empathy and compassion toward one's own experience is highlighted as a key outcome, alongside opening pathways toward healing.
- Understanding the connection between past events and current symptoms is framed as essential to targeting the right areas for healing work.

Dr. Alex Howard's Background and Credentials

- A personal experience of ME, also known as chronic fatigue syndrome, during his mid-to-late teens and early twenties served as the foundation for Dr. Howard's journey into psychology and healing.
- Over five years, thousands of hours of meditation and yoga were practised, more than 30 practitioners were consulted, and deep study of psychology and nutrition was undertaken in pursuit of recovery.
- Rather than finding a single answer, the healing journey revealed multiple contributing factors, leading to the development of an integrative, framework-based approach to trauma and chronic illness.
- Holding a PhD in psychology, Dr. Howard founded the Optimum Health Clinic approximately 23 years ago, which now employs over 25 full-time practitioners and serves around 1,000 active patients across more than 50 countries.
- Therapeutic Coaching, co-created by Dr. Howard, integrates core psychotherapeutic principles with solution-based coaching methodology and is offered as a two-year part-time professional training at therapeuticcoaching.com.
- The Reset Program, a 12-week online coaching initiative, was also developed to teach participants how to reset and regulate their nervous system.

Definition and Nature of Trauma

- Trauma is not defined solely by the events that occur, as two people can experience the same event and have entirely different outcomes.
- Neither is trauma defined purely by internal responses, as these vary across individuals and over time.
- Trauma is understood as a four-stage sequential process, beginning with events and ending with outcomes, with critical stages occurring in between.

The ECHO Model

- The acronym ECHO represents the four stages of trauma and also reflects the concept that past experiences echo into present life.
- Each stage of the model will be explored across the five days, with one stage addressed per session from day two onward.

- Events, the first stage, encompass both overt traumas such as abuse or parental addiction, and covert traumas such as growing up neurodiverse in a neurotypical family without recognition or support.
- Context, the second stage, refers to how well three core emotional needs are met during childhood, specifically the needs for boundaries, safety, and love.
- Boundaries relate to the capacity to assert personal limits and commitments, forming the foundation for willpower, personal strength, and the ability to persist through difficulty.
- Safety refers to the experience of co-regulation with caregivers, which becomes the internal foundation for self-regulation and the ability to settle when triggered in adult life.
- Love in this context means being valued for who one is rather than for achievements, forming the basis of self-esteem and self-worth.
- Homeostasis, the third stage, describes the shift in nervous system balance that occurs when events overload a person and core emotional needs are unmet, leading to a maladaptive stress response.
- Fight, flight, freeze, and fawn responses become normalised over time, with fawning described as an ultra people-pleasing pattern adopted to seek safety.
- A healthy stress response involves a temporary activation followed by a return to calm, whereas a maladaptive stress response keeps the nervous system in a state of chronic dysregulation.
- Outcomes, the fourth stage, include anxiety, depression, numbness, loss of meaning, self-medicating behaviours, and attachment difficulties such as anxious or avoidant patterns.
- Conventional medical and therapeutic approaches are noted to often focus on outcomes while overlooking the role of unmet core emotional needs and nervous system dysregulation.

Trauma Across the Lifespan

- Trauma is not limited to childhood and can occur at any point in life, including through loss, grief, or chronic illness.
- How an individual responds to adult trauma is largely shaped by patterns and defences developed during childhood.
- A case example from the YouTube series "In Therapy" illustrates how unresolved childhood grief compounded an adult's experience of loss, resulting in emotional shutdown rather than the ability to grieve.

Possibility of Healing

- Change is presented as entirely possible because the responses associated with trauma are learned behaviours that have become habituated over time.
- Just as maladaptive patterns were learned, new ways of regulating the nervous system and meeting core emotional needs can also be learned.

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- A structured map, practical tools, and a clear framework are identified as
the essential components needed to support this process of change.
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Next Steps

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- Participants are encouraged to attend each remaining daily session at the
same time, with the events of trauma to be covered on day two, core emotional
needs on day three, homeostasis on day four, and outcomes on day five.
- Completion of the Decode Your Trauma assessment tool is recommended prior to
upcoming sessions to maximise engagement with the framework.
- A lifetime access option is available for purchase, providing ongoing access
to the video series, a live daily Q&A with Dr. Howard, and an additional
workbook to deepen the learning experience.
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Key Points

- Decode Your Trauma is a five-day live-streamed series aimed at demystifying trauma, mapping how it shows up in daily life, and opening pathways toward healing.
- Sessions run across eight time zones via pre-recorded livestream, with a live Q&A staffed by qualified therapeutic coaches and Dr. Alex Howard.
- A beta Decode Your Trauma assessment tool (40–50 questions) generates a personalized report categorizing how trauma uniquely manifests for each participant, designed as a companion to the video series.
- Lifetime access is available for purchase, including unlimited video replay, a daily live Q&A with Dr. Howard on camera, and an additional workbook.
- Dr. Howard's framework is grounded in his own recovery from ME/Chronic Fatigue Syndrome, over 30 practitioners consulted, thousands of hours of practice, and a PhD in psychology.
- Optimum Health Clinic, founded 23 years ago, now operates with 25+ full-time practitioners, ~1,000 active patients across 50+ countries.
- Therapeutic Coaching — co-created by Dr. Howard — integrates psychotherapeutic principles with solution-based coaching and is offered as a two-year part-time professional training at therapeuticcoaching.com.
- Trauma is defined not as a single event or internal response, but as a four-stage sequential process captured in the ECHO model: Events, Context (core emotional needs), Homeostasis (nervous system), and Outcomes.
- Traumatic events include both overt traumas (e.g., abuse, parental addiction) and covert traumas (e.g., undiagnosed neurodiversity, normalized shame) — the latter often being more impactful precisely because they go unrecognized.

- Three core emotional needs — boundaries, safety, and love — form the context stage; unmet needs in childhood become the template for self-regulation and relational standards in adult life.
- When events overload a person and core needs go unmet, the nervous system upregulates into fight, flight, freeze, or fawn, creating a maladaptive stress response and chronic dysregulation.
- Outcomes such as anxiety, depression, addiction, and relationship issues are typically what people present to clinicians, but the two middle stages — unmet needs and nervous system dysregulation — are most often overlooked.
- Adult trauma responses are largely predetermined by childhood learning; the case of Paul illustrates how unresolved early grief (mother's death at age 2–3) compounded his inability to process his daughter's suicide.
- Healing is possible because trauma responses are learned and habituated — with the right map, tools, and framework, nervous system regulation and core need fulfillment can be developed.

Action Items

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Themes

- Trauma as a multi-stage process rather than a single event or moment
- The ECHO model: Events, Context, Homeostasis, Outcomes
- Childhood emotional needs: boundaries, safety, and love
- Overt vs. covert trauma and how both shape adult life
- The maladaptive stress response and nervous system dysregulation
- How past trauma echoes into present-day symptoms and behaviours
- The possibility of healing through a structured framework
- Anxiety, depression, relationship issues, addiction, and chronic illness as outcomes of unresolved trauma
- The role of self-regulation and nervous system reset in recovery
- Therapeutic Coaching as an integration of psychotherapy and solution-based coaching

Quotes

- "Trauma isn't one thing." - Dr. Alex Howard
- "Something happens in our past and it echoes. The study of trauma is really the study of how the past echoes in our present life." - Dr. Alex Howard

- "The walls of defense that we built to survive childhood become the walls of the prison that trap us in our adult lives." - Dr. Alex Howard
- "You can't think your way to a feeling." - Dr. Alex Howard
- "If we can learn to be one way, you can learn to be another." - Dr. Alex Howard
- "Sometimes we work so hard solving the wrong problem." - Dr. Alex Howard